

people that the real art is born; games that are memorable, masterpieces of design or just downright quirky and innovative. It is also from here that true legends such as Dark Souls are born.

Implicit game design

This is an element that is sorely lacking in today's games. Implicit game design simply refers to game design where the gamer learns through gameplay rather than tutorials. Too many games these days are just extended tutorials where the game will literally hold your hand to the very end. Objectives and even puzzles in-game are clearly highlighted and one can just blindly follow that marker on the map without putting an ounce of thought into the game. It's frustrating and insulting to a real gamer to have its hand held so much and takes the definition of mindless button-mashing to another level altogether. What happened to good ol' intelligence? Games like Half-Life got along magnificently without tutorials (we're not talking about the introductory tutorial). The game taught you to explore, look for vents, observe the environment, look for crates to climb or smash, doors to open and puzzles to solve. There was never any map nor was there any sort of massive hint plastered across the screen. The game made you use your head and put your brain through its paces. Usable items were not big, glimmering objects on your screen and the game really taught you to observe your environment while playing.

Mind you, the game wasn't very hard, even a kid could finish that game with a minimum of effort because the game was so well-designed. We're fairly certain that any game that tries something like that today will be considered too difficult. Games like Metro or Hitman today, provide the same level of difficulty as the games of Half-Life's time by giving you a supposedly super-hard difficulty level without hints and markers where you have to use your head rather than blindly follow on-screen indicators. This isn't super-hard, this was normal gameplay 15 years ago. Games that involve you mentally are the games that you will remember long after you finish



Half-Life: A true classic and a study in intelligent design

playing them. Portal and Limbo are perfect examples of such games. These are cerebral games that teach you while you play and somehow manage to entertain you at the same time. Some of the levels can be very hard, but by the time you reach that stage, you'll consider those levels a challenge rather than "extreme difficulty". By the time you reach that stage the game would have taught you enough, and accepted that you've learnt enough to handle that level on your own. Games need to grow up, they've been dumbed down far too long and they need to credit the average gamer with more intelligence than they do now. This isn't that hard.

Silver lining

One hope that the real gamers do have is the fact that everyone is playing games and the fact that developers want everyone to play games. Yes, we've ranted about how the average gamer is the target audience and how big-name developers are diluting their franchises to cater to this average



There is always hope

gamer, but please bear with us.

When everyone starts playing games, the average skill level of a gamer will slowly rise up to a level that is acceptable to the real gamer. Right now, the average gamer is clamouring for more and more games and is getting them. But also getting inundated with them. As the average gamer's skill improves, it's inevitable that the average game will also improve. This is a slow process that does leave many real gamers in the lurch at the moment, but at least,

there is hope for a better future. A future that we, as real gamers, can shape.

The real gamers should not remain content to sit behind and watch the rise and fall of the industry they love so much with resentment and resignation, they should do their best to help further this industry. They should support the really good games, organisations such as kick-starter are the perfect hunting ground for up and coming games and developers that need help.

Experienced gamers can slowly seep into the core of the industry itself, use their influence to improve the games that they so love. Intelligent game design never died out completely.

Game development just became more approachable and the average person is just learning how to play games. This should be an exciting time for the real gamers as the potential is there. There are hundreds, if not thousands of up and coming developers in the world now, many of them the real gamers of yesteryear who've gotten an opportunity to realise their dreams and we, as real gamers need to be there to show our support for them.

We must not let the art of gaming and game design just die out. All those years of gaming experience shouldn't just be allowed to rot away while we wait for the industry to grow up again. We can do something about it and we should. Standing idly by is not the way of the true gamer. Wake up. 